



The injury of Ederson before the tournament may not trouble Brazil's first-team plans — with Alisson set to start between the sticks. But the former's absence as the most reliable backup can make the team vulnerable if the Liverpool goalie picks up an injury.

Dorival's young boys will have an opportunity to set the stage for the 2026 World Cup, part of which will also be played in the USA. And a change of guard in Copa could be the perfect prelude to Samba, two years later.

Beyond the obvious

Though Brazil and Argentina remain the clear favourites, Messi's former coach Marcelo Bielsa will enter the tournament as Uruguay's coach, banking on a balanced mix of youth and experience to pack a punch in the USA.

While its highest-ever goalscorer Luis Suárez will play his fifth Copa, the side's engine room will be powered by Manuel Ugarte (right, in blue), Rodrigo Bentancur, and Federico Valverde — all of whom play their club football in Europe.

With Edinson Cavani retired, Darwin Nunez will look to step up, playing his first Copa America.

Though the tournament has seen

Talented bunch: Led by Vinicius Junior (third from right) Brazil's assembly line of attack extends to its bench, with Endrick (21), Gabriel Martinelli and Savio. REUTERS

the domination of the Big Three — Argentina, Brazil, and Uruguay — upsets have not been rare. Whether it was Argentina's loss to the USA in 1995 or Peru beating Brazil in 2016, the tournament has maintained football's appetite for unpredictability.

This is where Colombia comes in as the dark horse, riding on a 22-game unbeaten streak since its last loss against Argentina in February 2022.

With an in-form No. 9 in Rafael Borre, who has four goals in his last five games for club and country, and James Rodriguez pulling strings in the midfield, Colombia has won seven onsecutive matches going into the tournament.

Liverpool winger Luis Diaz on the left only adds further firepower to the side, which beat Brazil, Spain, and Germany within the last

year.

Though potential challengers like the USA, Chile, and Mexico exist, it remains highly unlikely, given the experience and squad depth of the conventional favourites, that they pose more than a faint possibility of winning.



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